

MGT 414: Rady Action Project

Fall 2026- Executive MBA

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Office hours are available by appointment.

COURSE DESCRIPTION

This course provides students with external consulting experience that utilizes and builds upon the knowledge and skills acquired through work experience and in this course. The course enriches the Rady experiential learning component and provides an interdisciplinary approach to project execution and presentation. Projects are sponsored by and guided by clients from the business community.

OBJECTIVES

- Gain a practical understanding of management consulting via hands-on experience working with a corporate client.
- Gain an in-depth understanding of advanced management techniques, including project and client management, communication, and team dynamics.
- Perfect use of business communications skills, oral and written, throughout the quarter, culminating in a final oral presentation and written executive summary.
- Learn best practices for aligning client expectations with realistic project goals and objectives through effective communication and consensus building.
- Create and deliver a well-thought-out and professionally executed final deliverable to the client

MATERIALS

The readings listed below are necessary to complete the course successfully. They give students another perspective on consulting. All articles can be found on the course Canvas site.

Required Readings- Prior to the start of the course

The following readings and video should be completed before the 1st class.

1. *Principles of Effective Consulting*
2. *Consulting Is More Than Giving Advice*—Arthur N. Turner
3. *Pioneers, Drivers, Integrators, and Guardians*—Suzanne M. Johnson Vickberg & Kim Christfort (Harvard Business Review, 2017)
4. *Glossary of Consulting Terms*
5. **Video:** [*Is Consulting the Right Career for You?*](#)—Harvard Business Review

These readings are assigned throughout the quarter:

6. *Project Scoping* — University of Virginia, Darden Business Publishing (UV8820 Rev. May 29, 2024)
7. *Want Bulletproof Strategies? Become a Better Problem Solver*
8. *Skills for Tomorrow: A Management Team in Crisis* — Ivey Publishing (W1331)
9. *3 Steps to Identify the Right Strategic Goals for Your Company*

Supplemental Reading – These books are for those students interested in pursuing consulting.

- [*Consulting 101: 101 Tips For Success in Consulting*, by Lew Sauder](#)
- [*Project Management Book of Knowledge \(PMBOK\)*](#) by Project Management Institute (PMI)
 - FREE if you apply for student membership with PMI

PROJECTS

A Rady Action Project is sponsored by a company or organization. A typical project includes the following activities and can encompass a business problem that an MBA student can solve.

1. Engaging with clients to clarify the problem – interviewing, questioning.
 - a. Context
 - b. Background
 - c. Symptoms
2. Structure the problem – fishbone diagram, etc.
 - a. Determine Cause
 - b. Revise if needed
3. Analyze research –think of all the possibilities
 - a. Develop solutions – how does it relate to the root cause
4. Select a solution
 - a. Feasibility
 - b. Best Fit
5. Ongoing communication with the client throughout the course, sharing your insights and solutions, and revising as needed

Teams will consist of 3-6 students who receive project guidance from a project leader provided by the company and mentoring from faculty. In addition, teams receive business communications coaching from industry and academic professionals. Students must bring their business skills and professionalism to the team to achieve project objectives. You represent the Rady brand alongside our sponsors, who are also employers interested in hiring UCSD students.

COURSE WORKLOAD EXPECTATIONS

This course is structured over the **10-week** quarter. The course workload is estimated as follows:

Course Item	Estimated Hours
Research	2-3 hours/week
Problem Solving	2-3 hours/ week
Weekly Status Reports (Client and Internal) and Client Meeting Agenda	1-2 hours/ week
Work Plan Updates	1-2 hours/week
Individual Assignments	1-2 hours /week
Team Presentation Slides	2 hours/week
Final Presentation Practice	1 hour/week
Final Written Deliverables	1-2 hours/week

This averages approximately **11-12** hours/week. These estimates will vary depending on your existing knowledge level and your time commitment.

MEETING SCHEDULE & STRUCTURE

The course is primarily online, except for 3 in-person sessions.

Project teams will meet with faculty via Zoom once during Weeks 3-7 for 20 minutes to discuss their client consulting projects, review project status, progress, client management, challenges, issues to address,

and potential adjustments if necessary. Please work with Meredith Mendez e4mendez@ucsd.edu to schedule those sessions. The teams will meet with their clients and their own team weekly.

Meetings	Time Frame	Documents	Participants
Project Kickoff	Week 2 In Person—General Session with Faculty followed by a 2-hour meeting between student team and client	Teams will develop project charter and schedule weekly client status meetings. Teams will submit their project charter on Canvas for faculty review before sending the final charter to the client.	Faculty Student Team Client
Client Status Meetings	Weekly—Week 3-9 Schedule determined by client and student team (may be scheduled outside of class time)	Email to Client 24 hours before meeting: 1) Client Status Report	Student Team Client
Faculty Meeting	Anytime the team is available. They will meet once in weeks (3-7) Teams will work with Meredith to assign a 20-minute time.	Submit on Canvas 24 hours before Faculty meeting: 1) Work Plan 2) Client Status	Faculty Student Team
Student Team Meetings	Each team will decide when they will meet each week via zoom to discuss their project and its progress -Week 3-9	It is strongly encouraged that you meet weekly as a team.	Student Team
Presentation For Communications Faculty	Week 8: Teams meet with the Communications faculty for 40 minutes: Work with Meredith to schedule a time.	20 minute presentation and 20 minutes of feedback. Student team should select one member to take notes and send them to both faculty	Student Team Communications Faculty
Midterm Presentation for Faculty	Week 6 Present to Class	20 minute presentations with 10 minutes of feedback.	Faculty Student Teams
Client Final Presentation	Week 10 Present to Class and Client	Present to client for 20 minutes and 10 minutes for client feedback.	Faculty Student Teams Client

COURSE SCHEDULE

The course begins October 10 and runs for 10 weeks to Dec 5, 2026

Module	Wk	Date	Meet*	Readings/Activities	Assignment (Due Date)**
Module 0:	0	Sept 26-27	Online	Readings & Video: <i>Principles of Effective Consulting</i> <i>Consulting Is More Than Giving Advice</i> <i>Pioneers, Drivers, Integrators, and Guardians</i>—Suzanne M. Johnson Vickberg & Kim Christfort (Harvard Business Review, 2017) <i>Glossary of Consulting Terms</i> Video: Introduction to course and faculty. <i>AI strategy for course</i> <i>Is Consulting the Right Career for You?</i>—Harvard Business Review	(9/27) Introduce yourself on Discussion Board #1 – 2pts
Module	1	Oct 3-4	Online	Readings: <i>Project Scoping</i> <i>Want better strategies? Become a Better Problem Solver</i> Video: What is Consulting; Skills for Success Review Project Charter Template	(10-4) Post on Discussion Board #2- How will you approach time management and planning for your project? (3pts) Give examples for each (3 pts) (10/4) Comment on another post from your team (2 pts)
Module 2:	2	Oct 10-11	In-Person (10/10) 1-5 pm	(10/10) Lecture (1-3:00) (10/10) Client Kick-Off (3:00-5:00)	(10/11) Team Contract (15pts)
Module 3:	3	Oct 17-18	Online	- Team Meeting - Client Meeting - Faculty Meeting (Students must meet one time as a team with faculty between Weeks 3-7)	(10/18) Project Charter/Scope (50 pts) (10/18) Post in Discussion Board #3 – How you plan to manage client expectations (6pts) – Give at least one example (2pts)
Module 3:	4	Oct 24-25	Online	- Team Meeting - Client Meeting - Faculty Meeting (Students must meet one time as a	(10/25) Client Status (4pts) (10/25 1 st Work Plan (2pts) (10/21) Project Charter due to client

				team with faculty between Weeks 3-7) Read Case on Consulting and People Management: ▪ <i>Skills for Tomorrow: A Management Team in Crisis</i>	(10/25) Post on Discussion Board (SFT Case Study): Students are required to answer the two questions below (2 × 10 points) and provide comments on each question in two different classmates' posts (2 × 5 points), for a total of 30 points. 1. What are three big issues facing the SFT team of directors give two out of three (10 pts) & Comment on a peer's post (5pts) 2. What are your recommendations? Two out of 3 recommendations (10 pts) & Comment on a peer's post (5pts) 3. No written response required—Take a moment to imagine you're creating a client relationship map. Think about how each personality connects with others and with Alvarez. This would look similar to the Star Wars relationship map. <i>Submit your responses to Questions 1-2 on Canvas.</i>
Module 5:	5	Oct 31- Nov 1	Online	▪ Team Meeting ▪ Client Meeting ▪ Faculty Meeting (Students must meet one time as a team with faculty between Weeks 3-7) Watch Videos: ▪ Nancy Duarte: Common Structure of Greatest Communicators (TEDxEast) (18:11) ▪ Nancy Duarte: How to Create Better Visual Presentations - Stanford Graduate School of Business (3:01)	(11/1) Client Status (4pts) (11/1) Work Plan (2pts) (11/1) Midterm Peer Review (11/1) Post in Discussion Board #4-How has the work plan helped/ or not helped with planning and time management? (2pts) Give an example (6pts) Prepare midterm brief presentation (20 minutes limit)
Module 6:	6	Nov 7- Nov 8	In- Person (2/7) 1-5pm	▪ Midterm Presentation: 20 minutes (Feedback 10 min)	(11/8) Slide submission to Canvas (50pts) (11/8) Client Status (4pts) (11/8) Work Plan (2pts)
Module 7:	7	Nov 14& 15	Online	▪ Team Meeting ▪ Client Meeting	(11/15) Client Status (4pts) (11/15) Work Plan (2pts)

				▪ Faculty Meeting (Students must meet one time as a team with faculty between weeks 3-7) ▪ Reading: <i>3 Steps to Identify the Right Strategic Goals for Your Company</i> ▪ Videos: Frameworks, Big vs Small Consulting, Success in Consulting	)
Module 8:	8	Nov 21-22	Online	▪ Presentation to Communications Faculty: Each team gets a 40-minute session (20-minute presentation, 20 minutes of feedback) ▪ Team Meeting ▪ Client Meeting	(11/22) Client Status – (4pts) (11/22) Work Plan-(2pts) (11/22) Post in Discussion Board #5– Did the client status report you sent to the client weekly- help or not help to maintain client (2pts) expectations? Explain (6pts)
Module 9:	9	11/28-29	Online	▪ Team Meeting ▪ Client Meeting	(11/29) Client Status (4pts) (11/29) Work Plan (2pts) (11/29) Final Peer Review Readings: (11/29) Work Cited (10 pts) (11/29) Executive Summary (50 Pts)
Module 10:	10	12/5&12/6	In-Person (12/5) 1-5pm	Presentation: 20 minutes, Client feedback 10 minutes	(12/6) Slide submission to Canvas (12/6) Send Power Point, Work Cited and 2 Page Executive Summary to client

*In-person (Location:) and Online (Canvas and Office Hours)

**All assignments/assessments are due by 11:59 p.m. Pacific Time on the due date.

Disclaimer: Please note that the specifics of this Course Syllabus are subject to change, and you will be responsible for abiding by any such changes. Your instructor will notify you of any changes.

ASSIGNMENTS

- I – Independent, individual work only. No collaboration or consultation allowed.
- G – Students will work together in groups and turn in one assignment for the entire group.

Course Grading	Course Work	Points
G	Team Contract	15
G	Client Status Reports-4pts each (Week 3,4,5,6,7,8)	24
G	Project Charter	50
G	Work Plan- 2pts each (Week 3,4,5,6,7,8)	12
I	Discussion Board: SFT Case Study (Week 3)	30
G	Discussion Boards #1-6(Week 0,1,2,4,5,8)	34
G	Executive Summary	50
G	Work Cited	10
G & I	Midterm Presentation	50
G & I	Final Client Presentation	75
I	Professionalism/ Participation Grade	150
	Total	500

Written Assignments

- **Team Contract (G):** Outlines the roles and procedures the team will follow throughout the project.
- **Project Charter (G)** – Outlines the current client situation (business opportunity or challenge), project goals, scope of work milestones and associated timelines, deliverables, risk assessment, and the basic terms and conditions under which the work will be performed.
- **Work Plan(G)** – The detailed weekly breakdown of the scope of work milestones. WP is for internal use only and not shared with the client. You may input your project into Chat GPT and ask it to break down your tasks and milestones for your work plan. Although I will need names and details on the project plan.
- **Client Status Reports (G)** – The client status report is due to the client 24 hours in advance. This document allows the client to stay up to date on the progress of the project. You will also submit these reports weekly into canvas.
- **Case - Assignments (I)-** Review the case *Skills for Tomorrow: A Management Team in Crisis*. Answer discussion board questions and respond to two peers.
- **Discussion Posts** – Several discussion posts required throughout the quarter (Weeks 0,2,4,7)

- **Executive Summary (G)** - Approximately 1–2-page summary of project purpose, methodology, analysis, findings, actionable recommendations, and next steps, as applicable. The key is to be concise.
- **Works Cited (G)** – Reference listings, providing all sources utilized during the quarter. This document will be graded based on the criteria for proper APA citation.
- **Midterm Presentation (G & I)** —30-40-minute team presentation presented in Week 5 to class and faculty.
- **Final Presentations (G & I):** Final presentation to the client. This is the culmination of the project work. Your midterm and final client presentations will be graded on your ability to communicate your results clearly and effectively, translate them to your audience, your pace and transitions, and the relevance and quality of your analysis and explanation of research, as well as its connection to business goals.

PROFESSIONALISM

Professionalism is defined as participating actively in every aspect of your project and operating as an effective team member and student. The professionalism grade is drawn from peer and faculty grading.

PEER GRADING (I)

At Weeks 5 and 10 of the quarter, each student will complete and submit a “peer evaluation” form on Canvas. Students will be asked to provide feedback on the contributions of their teammates. Submitting this form is considered part of your class participation grade.

FACULTY GRADING

Faculty will provide feedback about each team member’s contribution to the project.

The criteria are:

- Showing up for meetings on time and being prepared for discussion
- Demonstrating understanding of the project and your contribution to the research and outcome
- Demonstrating active leadership and participation in activities
- Communication and Professional Dress while engaging with the client
- Effective Listening and incorporating feedback given during your project development

GRADING

Percentage	Letter Grade	Points
90-100	A	450 -500
80-89	B	400-449
70-79	C	350-399

COURSE POLICIES

ATTENDANCE

This is a hybrid class; there will be three in-person sessions and weekly meetings online with your client, your team, and two meetings with faculty, and asynchronous lectures and assignments.

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

Integrity of scholarship is essential for an academic community. As members of the Rady School, we pledge ourselves to uphold the highest ethical standards. The University expects that both faculty and students will honor this principle and in so doing protect the validity of University intellectual work. For students, this means that all academic work will be done by the individual to whom it is assigned, without unauthorized aid of any kind.

The complete UCSD Policy on Integrity of Scholarship can be viewed at:

<http://senate.ucsd.edu/Operating-Procedures/Senate-Manual/Appendices/2>

AI STRATEGY FOR THE COURSE

The overarching philosophy is use AI as a junior analyst.

Enhance, Don't Replace – treat AI as an input to group collaboration. It serves to augment, not substitute, student critical thinking and faculty guidance.

Final Accountability- Final responsibility for all deliverables rests with the student. Think of AI as a junior analyst working for you- you are the lead partner.

Ethical Guardrails -Transparency is paramount. Use of AI must be documented and cited in final reports.

RULES OF ENGAGEMENT (HOW SHOULD AI BE USED?)

Hallucination Check: Always verify outputs for errors or outdated information. AI is a reasoning engine, not a fact- checker

Academic Integrity: Plagiarism rules apply. Copy-paste without critical synthesis is prohibited.

Proper Citation: Mandatory footnotes and bibliography entries for all AI-assisted work components.

Responsible Use: Ensure sponsor data is never fed into public models without explicit security confirmation.

STUDENTS WITH DISABILITIES

A student who has a disability or special need and requires an accommodation in order to have equal access to the classroom must register with the Office for Students with Disabilities (OSD). The OSD will determine what accommodations may be made and provide the necessary documentation to present to the faculty member. The student must present the OSD letter of certification and OSD accommodation recommendation to the appropriate faculty member in order to initiate the request for accommodation in classes, examinations, or other academic program activities. **No accommodations can be implemented retroactively.**

Please visit the [OSD website](#) for further information or contact the Office for Students with Disabilities at (858) 534-4382 or osd@ucsd.edu.